

7.1 Where most people live

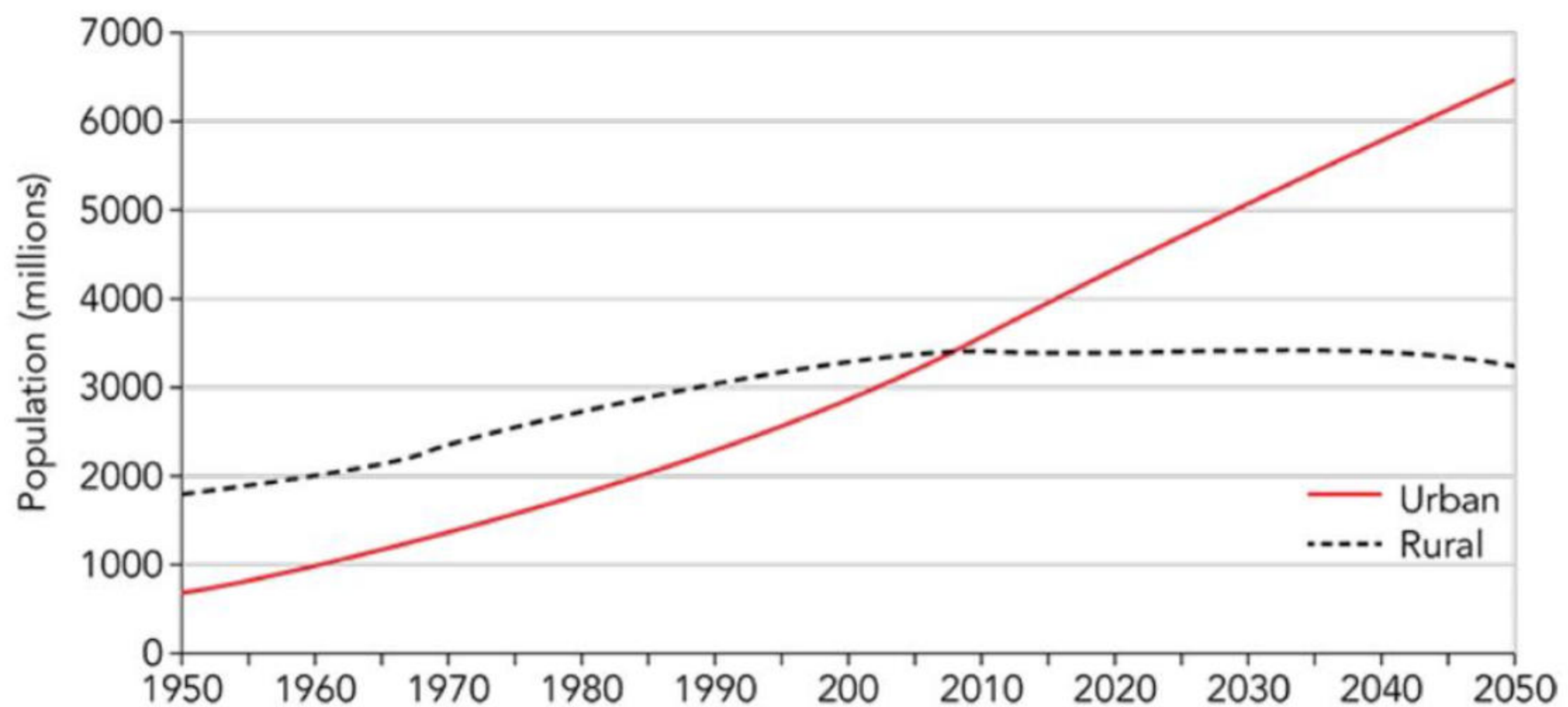
In 2024, 56% of the world's population, approximately 4.4 billion people, live in cities. The urban population is expected to more than double its current size by 2050 so that by 2050, nearly seven out of every ten people will live in cities. The number of cities with over ten million people is also increasing. Today, there are at least 33 of these cities, mostly in LICs and MICs in Asia, Africa, and Latin America.

Causes of urban growth

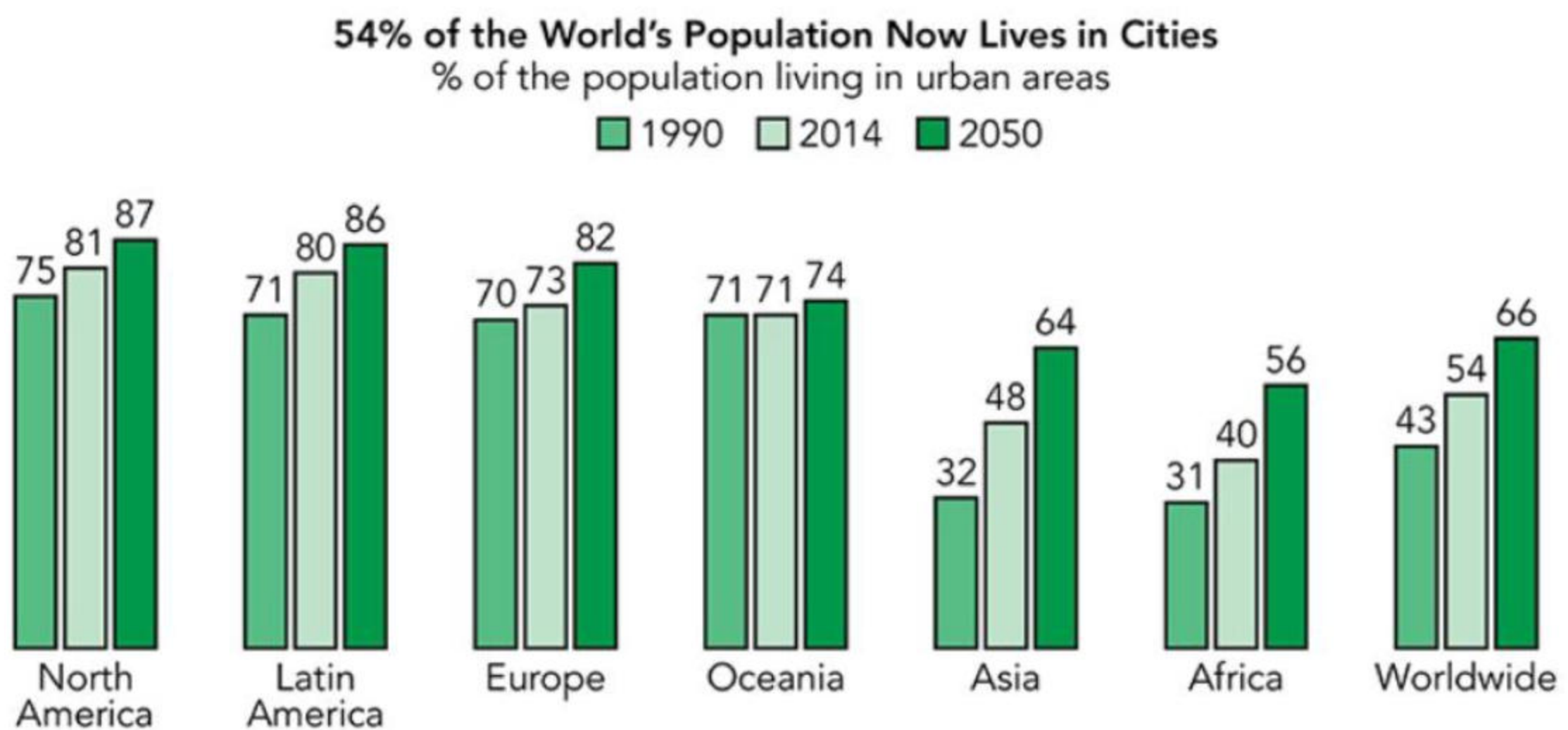
Urban growth refers to the increase in the population size and/or physical area of a town or city. It is one of the major changes of global significance in the world today. Urban growth occurs because of two main reasons:

- 1 In many large towns and cities, especially in LICs and MICs, there are more people being born than are dying. When the birth rate of an area exceeds the death rate, this is called natural population increase.
- 2 There are more people, especially in LICs and MICs, moving into cities from rural areas. This is called rural to urban migration. People are moving to large towns and cities due to a combination of 'push' and 'pull' factors.

The process of **urbanisation** mainly occurs when young adults move from rural settlements to larger towns and cities in search of a better quality of life. Some people move temporarily (with the intention of returning to rural areas in the future) and others may decide to move permanently.



Source **C**: Urban and rural population of the world, 1950 to 2050 (actual and projected)



Source: United Nations

Source **D**: Population living in urban areas by region, 1950 to 2050 (actual and projected)

- a Define the terms 'urbanisation' and 'urban growth'.
- b Using Source C, **in which year** did the global urban population exceed the rural population?
- c Using Source D:
 - i **Compare and contrast** the changes in urbanisation over time between Europe and Africa.
 - ii Suggest reasons for the projected increase of urban population in Asia.

248

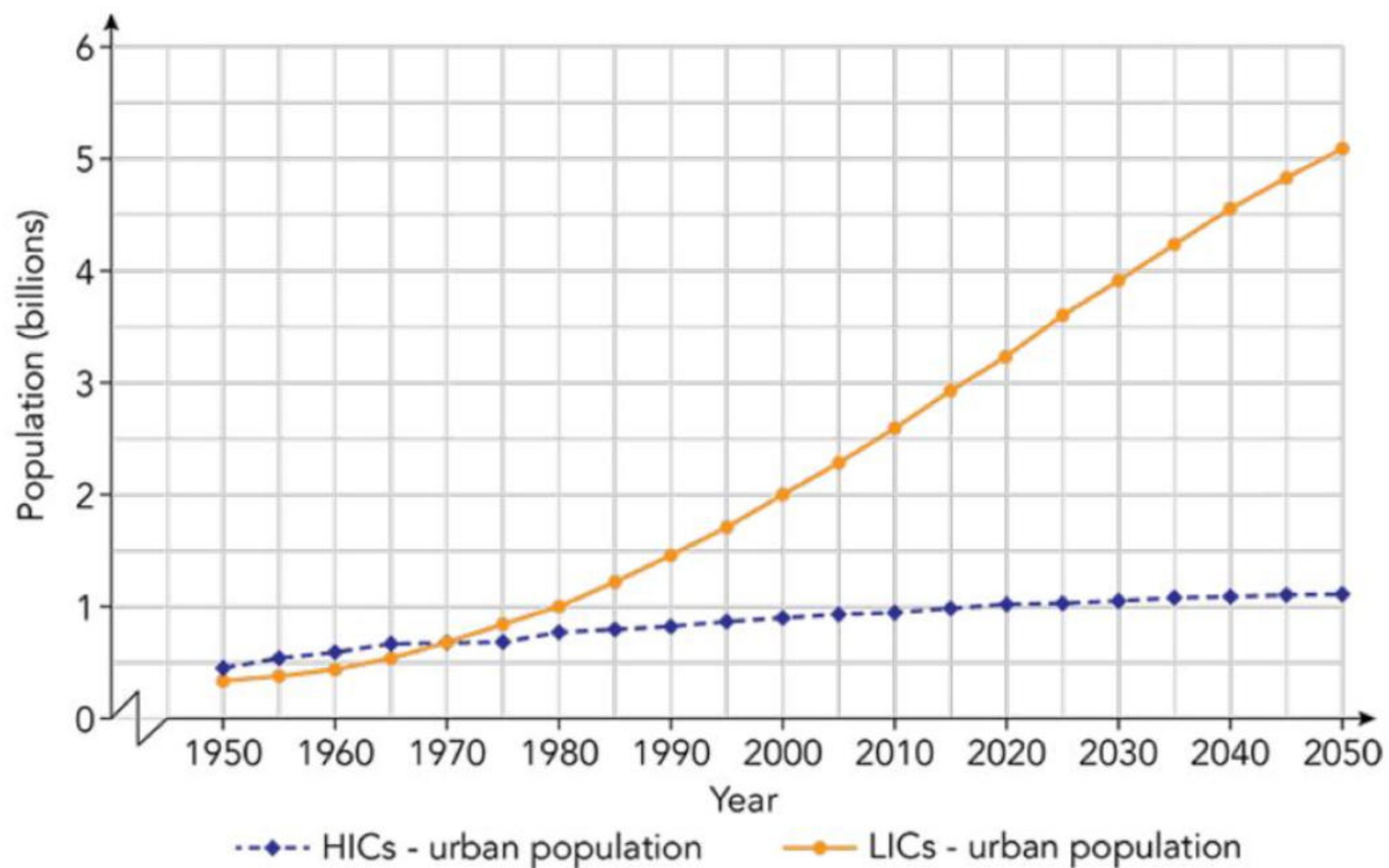
TIP

Urban growth means the increase in the population size and/or physical area of a town or city. It reflects the population growth occurring within cities and towns. Urban growth is a consequence of both the inward migration of people and the physical expansion of the urban area. Urbanisation is the increasing proportion of a country's population living in an urban area. Urbanisation is typically expressed as a percentage of the total population living in urban areas.

Variations in urban growth

The global urban population is projected to increase by 2–3 billion over the next 30–40 years. However, this growth will vary significantly between large towns and cities across the world. It is large towns and cities in LICs that will experience the most rapid urban growth (Source E).

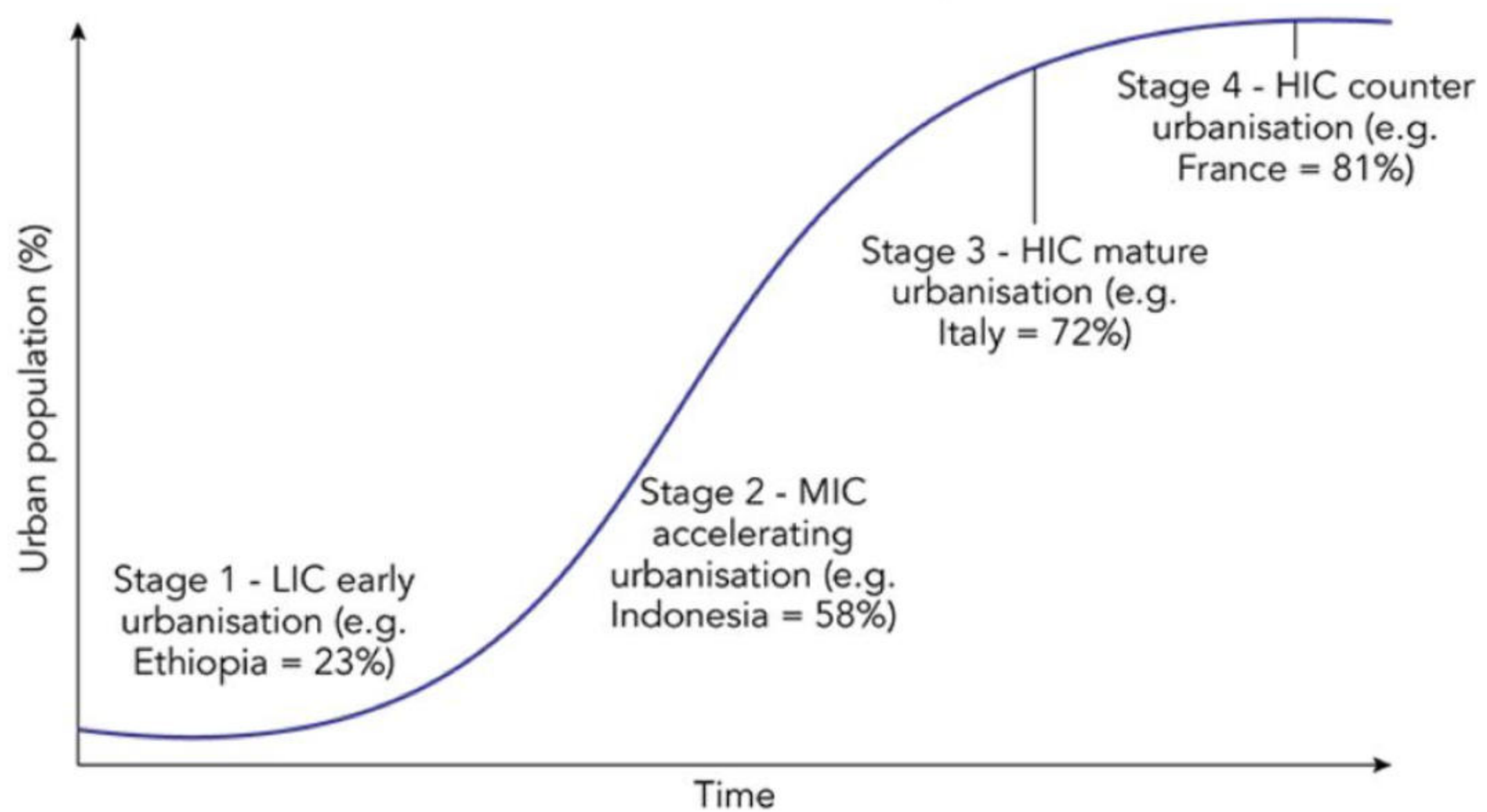
In many HICs, for example, in Europe and Central Asia, rates of urbanisation are much slower than in LICs and even declining. The process of rapid urbanisation and urban growth has already happened in HICs. This is because a large proportion of the population already lives in towns and cities. The average age of people living in urban areas has increased, and therefore, the fertility rate is declining. Many large towns and cities in HICs are actually experiencing **counter-urbanisation**. These differences between LICs and HICs can encourage us to think of an **urbanisation pathway** (Source F). Countries become more urban as they develop economically.



Source **E**: Urban growth of HICs and LICs, 1950 to 2050 (actual and projected)

249

The Urbanisation Pathway



Source **F**: The urbanisation pathway

Rapid urban growth in LICs

The continent of Africa has the youngest and fastest-growing population and also the highest urban growth rates in the world. A combination of rapid economic development, a relatively low share of the population currently living in urban areas, high rates of rural to urban migration within young adults, and the physical growth potential of many urban areas means urban growth will be more rapid in many LICs.

The highest rates of urbanisation mainly occur in LICs because:

- more new economic development is taking place in the large towns and big cities in LICs
- push-pull factors are leading to higher rates of rural-to-urban migration in LICs
- cities in LICs are experiencing higher rates of natural increase in the population.

Push factors make people want to leave rural areas and pull factors attract people to large towns and cities. These factors can be classified into economic, social, and environmental factors (see Tables 7.1 and 7.2).

Table 7.1: Rural push factors

Economic	Social	Environmental
Less job opportunities in rural areas	Lack of health and education services	Water shortages caused by more frequent droughts
Lower wages in rural areas	Lack of facilities such as shops, restaurants, theatres, and gyms	More extreme weather causing a lack of productive land and crop failure

Table 7.2: Urban pull factors

Economic	Social	Environmental
More job opportunities in large towns and cities	Better access to health and education services	Less vulnerability to extreme weather events
Potential of earning more money	Greater range of facilities	Greater food security

TASK 2: Study Sources **E** **F**

- Using Source E, **describe the predicted changes** in the urban population in HICs and LICs.
- Explain why rates of urban growth are projected to be faster and higher in LICs than HICs.
- Give two push factors and two pull factors of rural-urban migration.
- Study Source F. Why do you think the pace of urbanisation begins to slow and then flatten out or decline as countries develop economically?

City	Population in 2022	Estimated population in 2050	Percentage increase
Ahmedabad, India	8.5 million	13 million	+54%
Baghdad, Iraq	7.6 million	13 million	+13%
Chengdu, China	9.5 million	10.6 million	+11%
Chicago, USA	8.9 million	10.8 million	+21%
Dar es Salaam, Tanzania	7.5 million	16.4 million	+118%
Khartoum, Sudan	6.2 million	11.2 million	+80%
London, UK	9.6 million	10.8 million	+80%
Luanda, Angola	9 million	14.6 million	+62%
Nairobi, Kenya	5.2 million	10.1 million	+101%
Nanjing, China	9.5 million	10.4 million	+11%
Pune, India	7 million	10.8 million	+54%
Surat, India	7.9 million	12 million	+54%
Tehran, Iran	9.4 million	10.6 million	+13%

The term ‘megacity’ has been used to describe cities with populations of over ten million. In 2000, there were 18 megacities and, according to the UN, there are now 33. Around 50% of megacities are located in China and India. Some of these cities have populations that are bigger than the populations of entire countries. Mumbai, for example, has more people than Sweden and Norway combined.

In pairs, discuss the challenges and opportunities for people living in the next megacities and then make a list of the authorities who will have an important role to manage these challenges and opportunities.